Handoff 14: Decision log, handoff template and book outline (DOC-01, DOC-02)

Date: 2026-10-26 (America/Toronto)
Written by: Claude Code (implementer), overnight session
For: the human maintainer, and ChatGPT or Claude chat (reviewer) without repository access
Status: **in_review**: one pull request, not merged, not deployed. **Documentation only**: no application code, content, tests, settings or deployment changed.

> **How to use this file:** upload it with `build.md` (section 14, the updated handoff template), `docs/plan/decision-log.md` and `docs/plan/engineering-book-outline.md`. The pull request diff is the source of truth (`build.md` section 14). This is the first handoff written with the new template.

Starter prompt for the chat assistant

```
You are reviewing Python Academy DOC-01 and DOC-02, which are
documentation only: an updated handoff template with three new sections
(decisions and why, bugs found and fixed, how it was tested), a decision
log backfilled from handoffs 01 to 11, PRs and commits, and an outline
for a book and a CS50-style course built from it. I'm attaching build.md,
the decision log, the outline and this handoff. Check that every claim in
the log traces to a named source, that nothing missing was invented
(look for "reasoning not recorded"), that the plain-language explanations
are right for a first-year student, and that the glossary is accurate.
```

1. Where we are

Stage	What	Status
10	ASSESS-07 honest unit 1 checks	Merged (PR #16); your live check not yet recorded
11	ENG-03 browser behaviour checks	PR #17, open. This PR does not depend on it; the log describes it as in review
14	DOC-01, DOC-02 decision log	**in_review**: this PR

2. Handoff record (build.md template)

Field	Value
Task	DOC-01: every future handoff records decisions, bugs and testing. DOC-02: a decision log backfilled from the start, and an outline for a book and a course
Human goal	Keep the reasoning, mistakes and evidence behind the platform, so a first-year student can learn from how it was really built
Relevant build.md sections	14 (handoff template), 15 (learn while building), 18 (decision records)
Repository and branch	`torontojohn/python-academy`, branch `docs/decision-log`
Base commit	`27ab31b` (`main` after PR #16)
Implementer / reviewer	Claude Code / owner, plus ChatGPT or Claude chat
Deployment status	Not applicable (documentation only); not merged
New dependencies	None

Files changed

File	Change
`build.md`	Section 14's handoff template gains "Decisions and why", "Bugs found and how they were fixed" and "How it was tested", with a plain-language explanation of each and of unit, API, browser and live tests, mocks and deliberate-break controls. Section 2 lists the two new documents
`docs/handoffs/README.md`	Says that from handoff 14 on every handoff has the three sections, which also feed the decision log
`docs/plan/decision-log.md`	New. 14 chapters: the first version, the plan, stages 1 to 11 (ENG-01 to ENG-03), and recurring patterns. Each has the three sections, sources and a running glossary of 55 entries
`docs/plan/engineering-book-outline.md`	New. A 16-chapter book outline in 7 parts with appendices, and an 11-week CS50-style course with a final project

Acceptance criteria

- The handoff template includes the three sections, with terms explained for a first-year student. **Met** (`build.md` section 14).
- `decision-log.md` is backfilled from handoffs 01 to 11, the merged PR descriptions and the commits: one chapter per stage with the three sections, "reasoning not recorded" where it was not recorded, and a running glossary. **Met.**
- `engineering-book-outline.md` has a chapter outline for a long PDF and a CS50-style course outline using this app. **Met.**

- Handoff 14 in md and pdf; backlog not edited; nothing merged. **Met.**

3. Decisions and why

Decision	Options considered	Reason
Put the three sections inside the existing template in `build.md` section 14, with the explanations right under it	A separate template file	The template already lives there, and every handoff points to `build.md` section 14
One log chapter per **stage**, plus a chapter 0 for the work before stage 1 and a final "patterns" chapter	One chapter per handoff; one per PR	Stages match how the work was planned and reviewed. Stage 6 had two PRs (the bypass fix) that belong to one story
Add a chapter for the first version (PRs #1 to #3), although no handoff exists for it	Start at handoff 01	The task included "the commit history", and those PRs made the decisions everything else rests on (for example, never running learner code on the server)
Use the plan's recorded alternatives and consequences for decisions 1 to 23	Writing "reasoning not recorded" for all of them	`course-catalog.md` section 9 records alternatives and consequences. Where it gives a consequence but no reason, the log says so
Include small bugs that appear only in the implementer's session notes, labelled **(implementer's session notes)**	Leave them out	They are real and useful for teaching, and handoffs had no section for them before. The label makes clear they cannot be checked against a handoff
Describe stage 11 (PR #17) from its handoff on the open branch, marked "in review"	Leave it out until merged	The task asked for handoffs 01 to 11. The log changes nothing in that PR
Number this handoff 14	Number it 12	As the task asked. Numbers 12 and 13 are left unused, as assumed in section 7

4. Bugs found and how they were fixed

No bugs in code, which did not change. Found while writing the log:

- **Handoff 11 omitted two bugs** that the new Playwright tests had caught and that were fixed before the PR:
- the wrong line number for `EOFError`
- a last line of output lost without a newline

They are now in the decision log, chapter 12, labelled as session notes. This is exactly the gap the new template closes. - **Handoff 06's small test-writing fixes** (the `localhost` origin, test addresses, Chromium Local Network Access, an ambiguous locator) were also never recorded in a handoff. They are now in

chapter 7, labelled the same way. - **First draft of the log:** it said "reasoning not recorded" for the owner's decisions 1 to 23, although `course-catalog.md` section 9 records alternatives and consequences. It was corrected before the PR, after re-reading that section.

5. How it was tested

- **Source checks:**
- Every chapter names its sources (handoffs, PRs, commits).
- Every table row was written from those sources, which were re-read in this session: handoffs 01 to 04 in full, PRs #1, #2, #3 and #6, the commit messages, and `course-catalog.md` section 9. Handoffs 05 to 11 were written in this working session and re-checked against their text.
- **Link check:** every relative link and every in-page anchor in the two new documents resolves (scripted check).
- **Full test suites,** run although nothing executable changed, to show `main` plus this PR is still green:

Command	Result
`cd backend && .venv/bin/python -m pytest -q`	`213 passed, 9 skipped`
`cd frontend && npm run build`	Compiled successfully
`cd frontend && CI=1 npm run test:e2e`	`30 passed`

- **Mocks:** none; documentation only.
- **Deliberate-break controls:** not applicable; there was no code to break.
- **What a review should check:** this log is a summary written by the implementer, so a second reader should spot-check a few rows against their named sources. The starter prompt asks for that.

6. Backlog changes (not edited, as instructed)

Please add when convenient:

ID	Priority	Item	Depends on	Status
DOC-01	Next	Every handoff includes "Decisions and why", "Bugs found and how they were fixed" and "How it was tested" (`build.md` section 14)	None	in_review (handoff 14)
DOC-02	Later	Decision log (`docs/plan/decision-log.md`), kept up to date each stage, and a book and course built from it (`docs/plan/engineering-book-outline.md`)	DOC-01	in_review (handoff 14): log backfilled and outline proposed; book and course not written

Also add a stage row: "14. DOC-01 and DOC-02 | Decision log and handoff template | in_review (handoff 14)". The rows for stage 11 (ENG-03) are listed in handoff 11 section 6.

7. Assumptions

1. **Handoff number 14**, as asked. If 12 and 13 are meant for other work, those numbers are free; nothing here refers to them.
2. **"Stage" chapters:** the log groups PR #11 and its fix PR #12 into one chapter, and adds chapters 0 (first version) and 1 (plan), which had no handoffs.
3. **The CS50-style course** borrows only the format (lectures, sections, problem sets, final project). It is not affiliated with Harvard or CS50, and the outline says so.
4. **The book and course are not written yet,** only outlined. Publication and audience are open decisions (outline section 5).

8. Live checks for you

Nothing is deployed by this PR. Instead:

- [ ] **Template:** open `build.md` section 14, "Handoff template". The three new sections appear between "Data migration / compatibility implications" and "Known limitations", with the explanations below the template.
- [ ] **Spot-check the log:** pick any two rows in `docs/plan/decision-log.md` and open the named source (for example handoff 07 for chapter 8). The row should say what the source says. Note any row that doesn't.
- [ ] **"Reasoning not recorded":** search the log for it. There should be a handful, mainly in chapter 0 (the stack choice and the age rules) and in decisions where only a consequence was recorded. If you remember a reason, tell me and I will add it with "(owner, recalled on)".
- [ ] **Outline:** read `docs/plan/engineering-book-outline.md` section 5 and answer the four open decisions when ready.
- [ ] **PDF:** open `docs/handoffs/2026-10-26-14-decision-log.pdf` and check it renders.

9. Questions for the owner

1. Can you supply the missing reasons for the first version (chapter 0): why this stack, and why the age rules of 13 and over 25? I will record them as recalled, with the date.
2. The four open decisions in the outline, section 5: audience and publication, repository access for students, format, and order.

10. Next concrete action

The owner reviews and merges this PR and adds DOC-01 and DOC-02 to the backlog. From the next stage on, each handoff uses the three new sections, and its content is added as a new chapter of `decision-log.md`.